Athens experienced just such a shift at the time of Sophocles, Plato and Aristotle in the fifth century BCE, and so did the *mahajanapada* of Magadha in Northern India at much the same time, spearheaded by such thinkers as Vardamana (better known as Mahavira), founder of Jainism, Gautama Sakyamuni, founder of Buddhism, and Kakkhali Gosala, founder of the Ajivika movement, which at one time rivalled the other two heterodoxies.

What all these thinkers had in common was their determination to apply pure reason in the pursuit of knowledge, even if that meant challenging long-held beliefs. I do not believe it to be an exaggeration to say that in 1784 this 'emancipation of the human consciousness' returned to India.

Whichever side of the Orientalist argument you take, the fact remains that through their enquiries, translations, publications and exchanges of ideas, Jones and his fellow Orientalists made possible a diffusion of knowledge that had hitherto been confined to privileged elites and closed circles of initiates, or not even known at all. In doing so, these Orientalists initiated a process of revitalisation that had far-reaching consequences in India. One of the chief instruments for this revitalisation was Calcutta's Fort William College, an institution that has been described by the late Professor G. P. Deshpande of Jawaharlal Nehru University as 'the single most important intervention that colonialism made in the cultural life of India in the last two centuries'.[8] Scarcely less influential was Madras's Fort St George College, where young British probationer administrators and officer cadets rubbed shoulders with local language teachers and scholars. The outcome was that increasingly Western-educated and more politically aware sections of the populace began to challenge the status quo; not only British colonial rule but also religious orthodoxy of every sort, whether imported or local.